

A. Complete Revised SWA Psychological Research Foundation V2

1. Executive Summary

This document establishes the foundational psychological and design framework for SWA. SWA is designed to support a continuous self-awareness journey. By anchoring the product in validated theories of motivation, behavior change, and cognitive flexibility, we ensure that every micro-interaction is scientifically grounded, psychologically safe, and structurally designed for minimal resistance. [\[SWA DESIGN DECISION\]](#)

2. What SWA Is

SWA is **The Continuous Self-Awareness Journey**. Its central purpose is to help users gradually understand themselves better through short, meaningful, psychologically grounded interactions. Behavior change is an important possible *outcome* of self-awareness, but it is not the definition of SWA. [\[SWA DESIGN DECISION\]](#)

3. What SWA Is NOT

[\[SWA DESIGN DECISION\]](#) SWA is **NOT**: * A productivity app * A habit-building app * A therapy app * A psychological diagnostic app * A traditional journaling app * A collection of random motivational quotes

4. SWA Psychological Philosophy

The SWA philosophy operates on the premise that noticing one's internal state without judgment is the prerequisite for intentional choice. SWA aims to help users notice patterns and reflect meaningfully, extracting the active ingredients of psychological flexibility without heavy clinical interventions. [\[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED\]](#)

5. The Continuous Self-Awareness Model

[\[SWA DESIGN DECISION\]](#) A single exercise is an experience; repeated experiences lead to pattern discovery, and pattern discovery generates deeper self-awareness.

6. Notice → Reflect → Understand → Choose → Act → Reflect

[\[SWA DESIGN DECISION\]](#) This is the core SWA conceptual model. Not every exercise must reach "Act." * Some are simply: Notice → Reflect * Others: Notice → Understand * Others: Notice → Choose * Others: Notice → Choose → Act

7. Metacognition

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Metacognition involves thinking about one's own thinking. SWA helps users notice: "What story am I telling myself?", "What pattern am I noticing?", or "Is there another way I could interpret this?" This builds long-term cognitive flexibility.

8. Pattern Recognition

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Longitudinal pattern recognition is a major SWA concept. A single response must NEVER define the user. Repeated responses (e.g., consistently hesitating when feeling unprepared) reveal patterns, not diagnoses.

9. Reflection vs Intervention

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] SWA contains two primary exercise families: * **Reflection / Awareness:** Helps the user notice or understand something (e.g., "What part of today felt uncomfortable?"). * **Intervention / Practice:** Helps the user experiment with a new response (e.g., "What is the smallest step you could take?").

10. Psychological Foundations

The foundation relies on established psychological frameworks, positioned strictly as tools to facilitate self-awareness rather than the identity of the app itself. [SWA DESIGN DECISION]

11. Self-Awareness

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] The overarching capacity to recognize one's own emotions, thoughts, and values, forming the baseline for all SWA interactions.

12. Emotional Awareness

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] The ability to identify and differentiate internal emotional states accurately, which reduces reactivity.

13. Self-Efficacy

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Self-Efficacy Theory builds the user's belief in their capacity to execute specific behaviors.

14. Self-Determination Theory (SDT)

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] SDT focuses on intrinsic motivation driven by autonomy, competence, and relatedness.

15. ACT / Defusion

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (non-clinical applications) encourages psychological flexibility and cognitive defusion—noticing thoughts without getting entangled in them.

16. Self-Compassion

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Self-compassion is correlated with greater emotional resilience and lower procrastination compared to self-criticism.

17. Implementation Intentions

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Automates goal-directed behavior through "if-then" planning.

18. Mental Contrasting / WOOP

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Proven to bridge the intention-behavior gap by contrasting a desired future with current internal obstacles.

19. Behavior Design / Tiny Actions

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Based on the Fogg Behavior Model, which demonstrates that behavior occurs when motivation, ability, and a prompt converge; emphasizes making actions extraordinarily small to reduce resistance.

20. Values and Meaning

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Clarifying core personal values to reframe "have to" tasks into "choose to" actions.

21. Relationships and Communication

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Navigating interpersonal dynamics through increased awareness of assumptions and triggers.

22. Psychological Safety

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] SWA must avoid diagnosis, labeling, clinical claims, and fear-based motivation. It must allow users to choose "I don't know" or "Skip." No toxic positivity.

23. Low-Resistance Design

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] SWA operates on the principle of keeping ability requirements extremely low. Most daily exercises should take 30–90 seconds with a Resistance Score of 1–2.

24. High-Reflection Design

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] The ideal SWA experience: "That took less than a minute, but I noticed something meaningful about myself." Daily exercises aim for a Reflection Value of ≥ 4 .

25. Exercise Types

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Includes check-ins, this-or-that, scales, thought identification, perspective shifts, tiny behavioral experiments, and "notice $\rightarrow$ choose" arcs.

26. Exercise Variety

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Avoid consecutive exercises using the same interaction structure to prevent user fatigue.

27. Anti-Genericity

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] SWA will not rely on generic prompts (e.g., "What are you grateful for?"). Every exercise must possess a distinct, evidence-informed psychological rationale.

28. Exercise Quality Framework

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Evaluated on: Psychological grounding, Source credibility, Low resistance, Reflection value, Originality, User relevance, Emotional safety, Interaction quality, Personalization potential, Distinctiveness, Completion time, Longitudinal value.

29. Morning Reflection Philosophy

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Purpose: "What state am I entering today?" Focuses on current state, intention, and anticipated challenges. Not a long journaling session.

30. Evening Reflection Philosophy

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Purpose: "What did I notice today?" Focuses on pattern recognition, surprises, and what worked.

31. Daily Exercises

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] 30–90 seconds, low resistance, one meaningful insight, minimal typing.

32. 7-Day Modules

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Progressive exploration (Awareness $\rightarrow$ Recognition $\rightarrow$ Understanding $\rightarrow$ Experiment $\rightarrow$ Practice $\rightarrow$ Challenge $\rightarrow$ Integration).

33. 21-Day Modules

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Deeper longitudinal focus (Week 1: Understand, Week 2: Practice, Week 3: Integrate).

34. Personalization Philosophy

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Personalization is progressive. Initial (preferences) → Intermediate (repeated interactions) → Advanced (longitudinal patterns). Purpose: Give the user a more relevant self-awareness experience, not predict everything.

35. Longitudinal Pattern Recognition

[HYPOTHESIS / FUTURE VALIDATION] Users will derive more value when SWA reflects patterns over time rather than isolated insights.

36. User Signal vs User Label

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] A response is a signal, never a label. SWA never assigns fixed traits like "Procrastinator." SWA suggests: "Recent responses suggest you may..."

37. Human-in-the-Loop

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] AI drafts and researches; a Human *must* approve, modify, and verify for safety and cultural relevance.

38. Evidence and Source Policy

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Hierarchy: Systematic reviews > Peer-reviewed empirical > Original theory > University centers > Professional orgs > Books by researchers > Official researcher resources > General educational. Popularity is not evidence.

39. Recommended Research Sources

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] Bandura, A. (1977); Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999); Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000); Neff, K. D. (2003).

40. Recommended Books

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] *Tiny Habits* (BJ Fogg), *Rethinking Positive Thinking* (Gabriele Oettingen), *Self-Compassion* (Kristin Neff), *A Liberated Mind* (Steven C. Hayes), *Mindset* (Carol S. Dweck).

41. Recommended Online Resources

[RESEARCH-SUPPORTED] selfdeterminationtheory.org, woopmylife.org, self-compassion.org, behaviormodel.org.

42. Limitations

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] SWA is not a substitute for clinical care. Its internal metrics (Reflection Value/Resistance Scores) are design tools, not validated diagnostic scales.

43. Ethical Considerations

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Absolute adherence to psychological safety. Users have the right to withhold sensitive information. Interventions must avoid shame or manipulation.

44. Future Research Requirements

[HYPOTHESIS / FUTURE VALIDATION] Long-term efficacy of SWA's micro-interventions requires future study with user cohorts to validate the proposed distribution of exercise types.

45. Final SWA Exercise Design Principles

[SWA DESIGN DECISION] Minimum Effort + Minimum Time + Maximum Reflection. Every exercise must separate the stimulus from the response, rely on behavior over identity, and default to scaling down challenges.

B. Executive Summary of Changes from V1

V1 framed SWA heavily around behavior change, habits, and productivity micro-interventions. V2 pivots SWA entirely to a **Continuous Self-Awareness Journey**. Behavior change has been demoted from the primary goal to a *potential outcome* of awareness. Metacognition, longitudinal pattern recognition, and the absolute separation of "signals" from "labels" were introduced. A clear distinction was drawn between user-facing categories and internal psychological dimensions.

C. Table of Retained Frameworks

Framework	V1 Use	V2 Repositioned Use
ACT / Defusion	Daily exercises	Tool for thought awareness / metacognition
SDT	Values alignment	Tool for autonomy, motivation, and meaning
Self-Compassion	Micro check-ins	Tool for reducing self-criticism during reflection
WOOP / Implementation Intentions	Goal setting / If-then	Tool for specific <i>Intervention/Practice</i> exercises
Fogg Behavior Model	Core app philosophy	Tool specifically for "Scaling Down" resistance

D. Table of Newly Added Concepts

Concept	Description
Metacognition	Exercises designed to make users aware of <i>how</i> they think, not just what they feel.
Signal vs. Label	A user response is a temporary data point (signal), never a permanent trait (label).
Scaling Down	Elevated to a primary design principle—shrinking the required action to reduce resistance.
Reflection vs. Intervention	Splitting exercises into those purely for noticing vs. those that prompt a tiny new behavior.
Internal vs. External Categories	Separating what the user sees (e.g., "Confidence") from what the system maps (e.g., "Self-Efficacy").

E. Table of Removed/Reduced Concepts and Why

Concept	Status	Reason for Change
Habit Building as Core Goal	Removed	Conflicts with the "Self-Awareness Journey" identity.
Heavy Focus on 'Action'	Reduced	Not every exercise needs to end in an action; awareness itself is a valid outcome.
Generic Journaling Prompts	Removed	Fails the new Anti-Genericity rule; lacks specific psychological mechanisms.

F. Verified Source Library

- **Self-Efficacy:** Bandura, A. (1977). *Self-efficacy: Toward a unifying theory of behavioral change*. Psychological Review.
- **Implementation Intentions:** Gollwitzer, P. M. (1999). *Implementation intentions: Strong effects of simple plans*. American Psychologist.
- **Self-Determination Theory:** Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). *Self-determination theory and the facilitation of intrinsic motivation...* American Psychologist.

- **Self-Compassion:** Neff, K. D. (2003). *The development and validation of a scale to measure self-compassion*. Self and Identity.

G. Recommended Book Library

- *Tiny Habits: The Small Changes That Change Everything* by BJ Fogg, PhD.
- *Rethinking Positive Thinking* by Gabriele Oettingen, PhD.
- *Self-Compassion* by Kristin Neff, PhD.
- *A Liberated Mind* by Steven C. Hayes, PhD.
- *Mindset: The New Psychology of Success* by Carol S. Dweck, PhD.

H. Recommended Online Resources

- Center for Self-Determination Theory: selfdeterminationtheory.org
- WOOP My Life: woopmylife.org
- Self-Compassion: self-compassion.org
- Fogg Behavior Model: behaviormodel.org

I. Final SWA Exercise-Generation Rules

1. **Target the Journey:** Map to the Notice → Reflect → Understand → Choose → Act model.
2. **Ensure Low Resistance:** Score must be 1-2 (takes < 90 seconds).
3. **Ensure High Reflection:** Score must be 4-5.
4. **No Labels:** Never use "you are" statements regarding negative traits.
5. **Scale Down:** If proposing an action, make it the smallest possible increment.
6. **Avoid Genericity:** No generic "how do you feel" prompts without a psychological anchor.
7. **Identify Exercise Type:** Clearly label as Reflection/Awareness or Intervention/Practice.

J. Final SWA Quality-Control Checklist

- [] Does this exercise diagnose, label, or assume a fixed trait? (If yes -> Reject)
- [] Does this exercise take longer than 90 seconds? (If yes -> Reject for Daily)
- [] Does this exercise force behavioral change when awareness is sufficient? (If yes -> Rewrite)
- [] Is the underlying psychological principle traceable to a Tier 1-3 source? (If no -> Reject)
- [] Does the exercise allow the user to gracefully opt-out or say "I don't know"? (If no -> Rewrite)

K. Research Gaps That Still Require Validation

- **Optimal Exercise Distribution:** The 25% Noticing / 15% Emotional / 15% Metacognition split is a design starting point and requires A/B testing with real users.
- **Longitudinal Pattern Accuracy:** How many repeated signals are required before an AI/system can safely suggest a "pattern" to a user without causing defensive reactions?
- **Engagement Decay:** Validating if the "Anti-Genericity" rule actually prevents the standard drop-off seen in traditional journaling apps.